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Medics responding to a morning strike on a residential area in Kramatorsk, Ukraine, where the journalist Olha Konovalova grew up.

A Journalist Watches War Come for Her Home

By OLHA KONOVALOVA

KYIV, Ukraine — On the morning of Aug. 4, two Russian guided bombs, each weighing more than 1,000 pounds, struck the residential block where I grew up in Kramatorsk, eastern Ukraine.

I learned of the attack from social media, scrolling through videos until I recognized a neighboring building in flames. Then came the frantic search for any piece of information on whether my home had also been destroyed.

Finally, a man who still lives in my building sent me a video, filmed from inside my flat. The fire had spared it, but not the blast. Shards of glass covered the floor. In the kitchen, the window frame had been torn from the wall. In the living room, the windowsill was gone entirely. Even the bathroom tiles had cracked.

Family Apartment in Ukraine
Evaded Damage for Years,
Awaiting the Inevitable

Russian forces have been advancing on Kramatorsk slowly but steadily, and I long knew that my childhood home would eventually find itself in the fight. Still, nothing prepares you for seeing the place you were born torn apart by bombs.

This is an experience shared by millions of people across Ukraine over four and a half years of war — those now watching their homes being damaged by the approaching fight, and those who’ve already lost them.

As a journalist, I have covered such stories repeatedly, watching city after

city being destroyed: Sievierodonetsk, Bakhmut, Avdiivka, Pokrovsk, Kostiantynivka. Now, it’s my hometown’s turn.

Kramatorsk is a small city filled with parks and childhood memories. I remember splashing in a fountain in the city center on hot summer days and sledding down the hill near my school in winter. On weekends, my mother and I would walk to the local farmers’ market to buy fresh milk and homemade cheese that we would devour with breakfast. A Georgian restaurant near our home became a favorite spot for family evenings over a khachapuri and wine, a birthday celebration or just a cup of coffee.

Everything changed on Feb. 24, 2022, when Russia launched its full-scale invasion. Explosions woke my parents in Kramatorsk and they called me in a panic

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Judge Declares
2nd-Home Tax
Needs Redoing

By MIHIR ZAVERI

A Staten Island judge dealt a major setback on Tuesday to Mayor Zohran Mamdani’s push to raise taxes on the wealthy, saying that the city had mishandled the rollout of a tax on high-end second homes and must start over.

The judge, Wayne M. Ozzi of State Supreme Court on Staten Island, sided with a group of homeowners who had sued the city. The homeowners had argued that the Mamdani administration’s Department of Finance did not try hard enough to determine who should owe the tax before moving toward collecting it.

“Homeowners are being substantially harmed and penalized needlessly by D.O.F.’s method of implementing the tax law,” Justice Ozzi wrote.

The lawsuit did not challenge the legality of the tax on second homes, also known as pieds-à-terre. Unveiled by Gov. Kathy Hochul of New York in the spring and backed by the mayor, the tax was popular among voters and hailed by Mr. Mamdani’s supporters as a way to make good on his pledge to “tax the rich.” It was expected to close a budget gap by raising some \$500 million annually to fund city services.

But the bumpy rollout of the policy on a short timeline drew immediate criticism from the may-

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TODD HEISLER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

‘They didn’t break me as a human,
which they can do, and they
choose who to do that to.’

In an interview, Evan Gershkovich, a Wall Street Journal reporter who was imprisoned in Russia for 16 months, described his ordeal and the moment that dealt him his lowest point. PAGE A8

Breach at F.B.I.
Leaves Workers
Fearful of Risks

This article is by Dustin Volz, Alan Feuer, Charlie Savage and Adam Goldman.

WASHINGTON — The theft by a criminal hacking group of reams of sensitive personal data involving potentially tens of thousands of former and current F.B.I. employees is emerging as one of the worst breaches of sensitive government information, leaving the bureau rushing to protect its personnel and what the total damage is.

More than a week after the group, known as ShinyHunters, revealed it had pilfered intimate details about bureau personnel from the agency’s jobs portal and threatened to leak them online, F.B.I. investigators were still piecing together how the breach took place and what the total damage is.

The hack appears to have swept up home addresses, Social Security numbers, secretive job assignments and much more, according to a New York Times analysis of some of the records. It is already being compared to China’s breach of more than 20 million records from the Office of Personnel Management over a decade ago, considered so catastrophic that officials and lawmakers vowed to never let something like that happen again.

Many F.B.I. employees learned

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OpenAI Failed
To Heed Alerts
About Security

Employees Had Warned
About Models Testing

This article is by Sheera Frenkel, Dustin Volz and Dylan Freedman.

SAN FRANCISCO — Months before OpenAI’s artificial intelligence went rogue, two employees raised an alarm with top executives. They were ignored.

In emails, the employees said they worried that OpenAI’s newest artificial intelligence models were not being appropriately monitored during testing to gauge the technology’s sophistication and to secure the models, according to messages viewed by The New York Times.

In response, OpenAI executives told the employees that the tests needed to move forward as quickly as possible to release the A.I. models on time. No additional security protocols were instituted, said the workers, who were not authorized to speak publicly on sensitive matters.

OpenAI’s models later broke out of their testing environments and attacked the A.I. start-up Hugging Face and other organizations, setting off a global debate about A.I. safety.

The exchanges between OpenAI employees and executives — which have not been previously reported — were part of a pattern where the San Francisco company did not prioritize security, according to employees and independent security researchers. That approach not only was evident with the testing of A.I. models, they said, but also showed up in other areas of the company, which makes the ChatGPT chatbot.

Independent security researchers said they found bugs in recent months that allowed them to view the internal communications of OpenAI employees. They also found other vulnerabilities that would enable them to see the company’s internal computer code and view the chat logs of ChatGPT users. When the re-

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OIL EXPORTS RISE
IN THE MIDEAST,
DESPITE ATTACKS

PRICES STILL ELEVATED

More Tankers Transiting
Strait, but Supply Is
Below Demand

By PETER EAVIS

Oil exports from the Middle East have risen sharply this month, some oil analysts say, taking them closer to the level they were at before Iran shut down the Strait of Hormuz in March, a rebound that could ease some pressure on global energy prices.

In September, an average of 10 million barrels of oil has gone through the waterway daily, according to Kpler, a firm that tracks oil tankers. Separately, six million barrels of crude a day has left the Persian Gulf states this month through pipelines and ports that bypass the strait, Kpler’s data shows.

Before the war with Iran began at the end of February, around 19 million barrels of crude left the region daily through the waterway and other routes. Because of the difficulty in tracking tankers, export totals supplied by analysts might not reflect the true flow of oil, but most experts say volumes rose significantly this month.

The turnaround has most noticeably occurred in the strait, even though Iran continues to attack tankers. A U.S. military operation aimed at protecting the vessels from the attacks appears to have encouraged more shipments by big exporting countries, like Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates.

“They are getting a substantial amount of oil out, and it is increasing over time as shippers’ confidence goes up,” said Eugene Gholz, an associate professor of political science at the University of Notre Dame and an expert on conflict in the strait.

President Trump, members of

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JULIE GLASSBERG FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Francis Lee Rogers painted birds and built feeders in the park, her home for decades. A man called her “a genuine special character.”

Her Art Uplifted Central Park.
Her Murder Leaves It Shaken.

By COREY KILGANNON and CHELSIA ROSE MARCIUS

Francis Lee Rogers was a fixture in Central Park’s Ramble, a wooded area that is popular with birders.

She spent her days painting the Ramble’s birds and kept her homemade network of feeders filled with seed, as legions of bird lovers walked by hoping to catch a glimpse of warblers and sparrows.

For years, Ms. Rogers, who was homeless, brushed off concerns about the perils of a woman in her 60s — or anyone, for that matter — spending nights in and around the Ramble as she largely had for decades.

On Sunday morning, Ms. Rogers, 63, was found dead, beaten and stabbed in the rustic wooden gazebo where she spent her nights, a short walk from the Central Park Boathouse, an upscale restaurant known for leisurely lunches and weddings.

She was found barefoot and covered in dirt, her body stabbed repeatedly and her head severely

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INTERNATIONAL A4-12

A Homecoming in Spain

The eviction of an 87-year-old set off huge protests in the country, which has an acute housing shortage. PAGE A9

Honoring the Dead, Sweetly

For one Istanbul confectioner, distributing fried dough balls as memorials is not just a job. It’s personal. PAGE A4



NATIONAL A13-23

Senator’s Perjury Claim Falters

A Republican eager to prove the former special counsel Jack Smith was dishonest appeared to instead display his own confusion over basic facts. PAGE A19

Mamdani’s Antisemitism Plan

A report issued by New York’s mayor cites hate crime prevention, but it avoids talk of Israel. PAGE A23

ARTS C1-6

Reframing the Picture

Lee Krasner, who was married to Jackson Pollock, is getting her share of the spotlight in a show at the Met. PAGE C1

FOOD D1-8

Thanks for the Order. Next!

An Indian-Pakistani strip mall joint, below, in Houston ranks as the world’s busiest Uber Eats restaurant. PAGE D1



Quickening the Pace

At Tiny’s Burger in Costa Mesa, Calif., the acclaimed chef Sang Yoon tries his hand at the fast-food game. PAGE D5

BUSINESS B1-5

A.I.-Run Propaganda

China, Iran and Israeli groups have combined open-source models and autonomous agents to wage influence campaigns, foreshadowing future online manipulation. PAGE B1

A ‘Toaster on Wheels’ Rolls In

The Amazon-owned driverless car company Zoox is a distant second to Waymo. Its pitch to riders? Wine pop-ups, festival sponsorships and a car built to be filmed. PAGE B1

OPINION A24-25

Bethany McLean

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SPORTS B6-9

They’re Passing the Bat On

A reunion of women whose experience was immortalized in the film “A League of Their Own” showcased the bright future of baseball for girls. PAGE B6



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